SPSP ANNUAL CONVENTION

ATLANTA

2023

Emotion Expression in Relationships:

Empathic Effort and Interpersonal Accuracy as Mechanisms

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#SPSP2023

Theoretical Background

Expressing emotions with others can be difficult as it puts individuals in a position of potential vulnerability.

People are more willing to express vulnerable emotions (e.g., sadness, anxiety, guilt) with those who care for their welfare, characterized as communal partners.

Why are people more willing to express their emotions with communal partners?

Le et al., 2018; Mills, Clark, Ford, & Johnson, 2004; Von Culin, Hirsch, & Clark, 2017

Theoretical Background

empathic effort

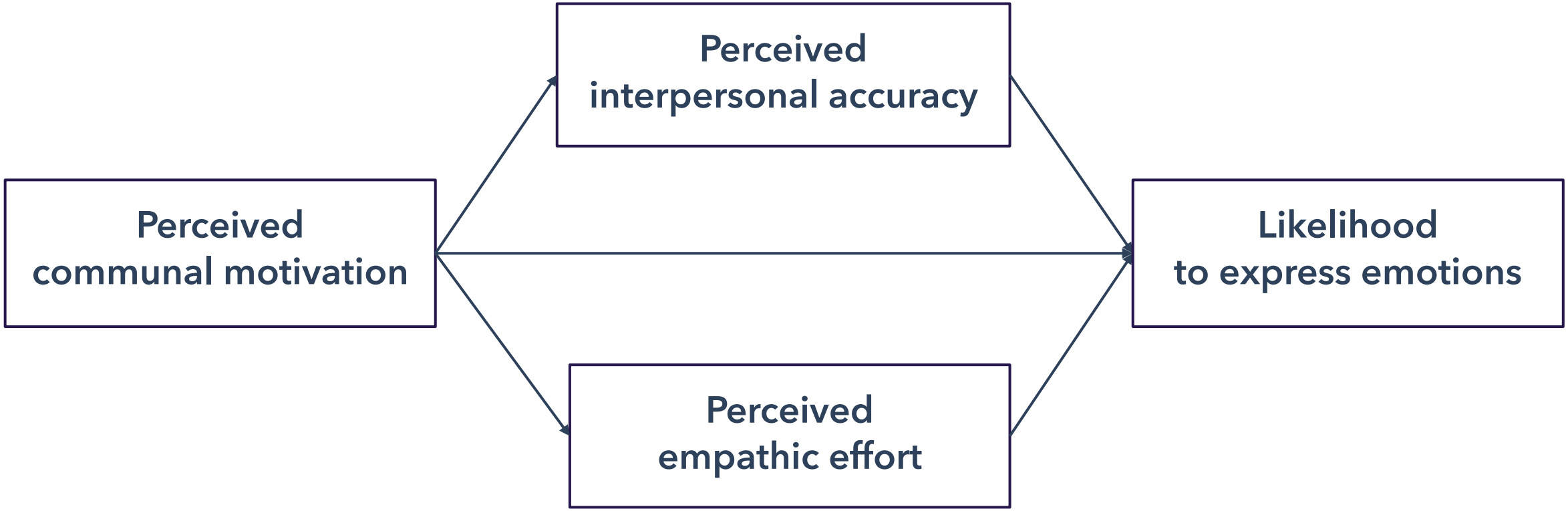
the motivation to understand another person's emotions by investing time or energy to feel empathy

interpersonal accuracy

the ability to accurately assess the emotions of others

Cohen et al. (2012); Schmid Mast & Hall (2018); Schumann et al. (2014)

Why are people more likely to express their emotions with partners who they perceive care for them?



Participants

Preregistered on AsPredicted

N = 219
Recruited from
Prolific and ResearchMatch

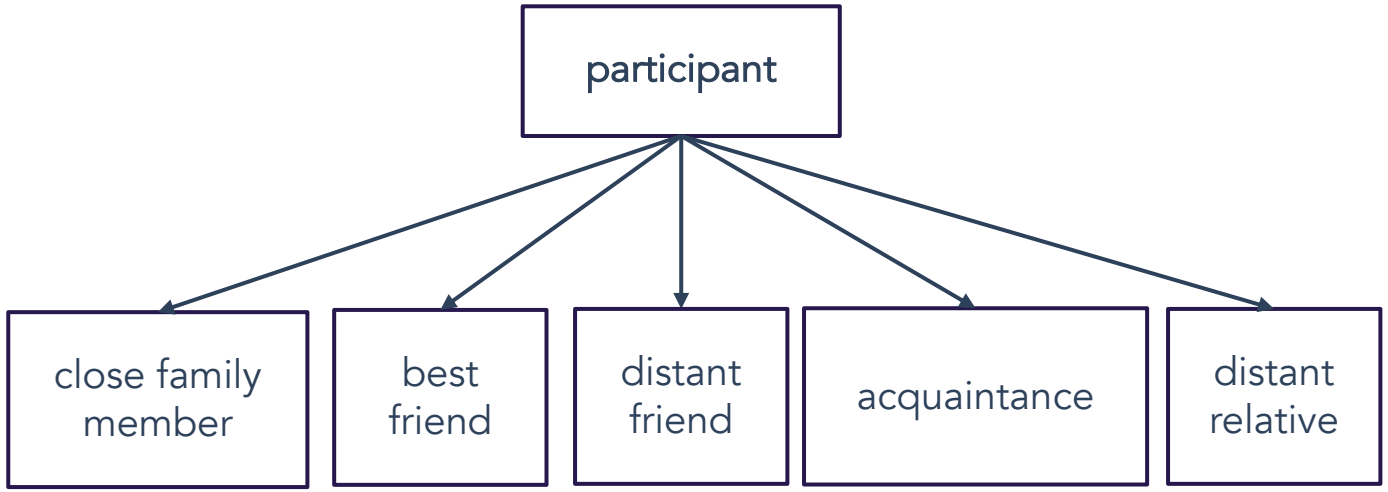
Age (*M* = 49.4 years)

Gender
135 females, 74 males, 6 non-binary,
4 self-described or preferred not to say

Race
80.4% White
11% Hispanic, Spanish, or Latin American
2.7% Black or African American
2.3% Asian
3.6% Other

Methods and Measures

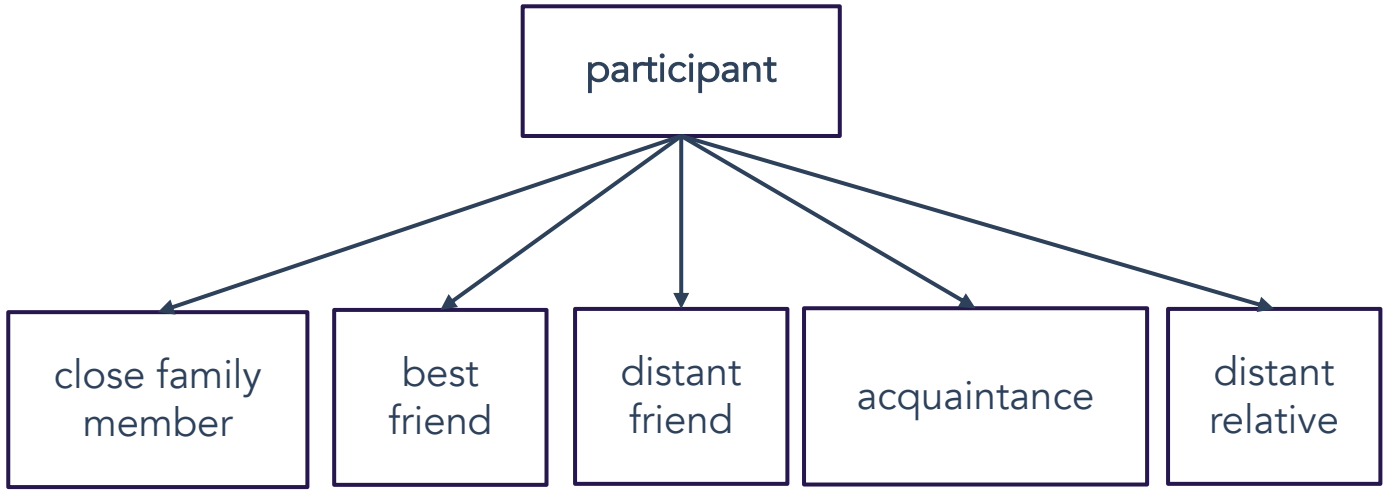
PERCEIVED COMMUNAL MOTIVATION



Participants report the communal motivation they perceived from each partner (Lemay, 2014).

Methods and Measures

PERCEIVED COMMUNAL MOTIVATION



Controlling for between-person effects: Individual differences in perceived communal motivation → individual differences in likelihood of expression

Within-person effects: within-person differences in perceived communal motivation (from different partners) → within-person variation in likelihood of expression

Methods and Measures

PERCEIVED COMMUNAL MOTIVATION

Participants reported their likelihood of expressing happiness, pride, gratitude, sadness, anxiety, anger, and guilt to each relationship partner.

LIKELIHOOD TO EXPRESS

When you experience sadness, how likely are you to express it to _____?

Von Culin, Hirsch, & Clark, 2017

Methods and Measures

PERCEIVED COMMUNAL MOTIVATION

Participants reported the likelihood that each relationship partner would demonstrate empathic effort when they expressed each emotion.

LIKELIHOOD TO EXPRESS

If I were to express sadness to _____,
_____ would put in a lot of effort to see things from my perspective.
_____ would really try to understand the situation from my point of view.
_____ would put a lot of thought into figuring out how I was feeling.

PERCEIVED EFFORT

Methods and Measures

PERCEIVED COMMUNAL MOTIVATION

Participants reported the likelihood that each relationship partner would demonstrate interpersonal accuracy when they expressed each emotion.

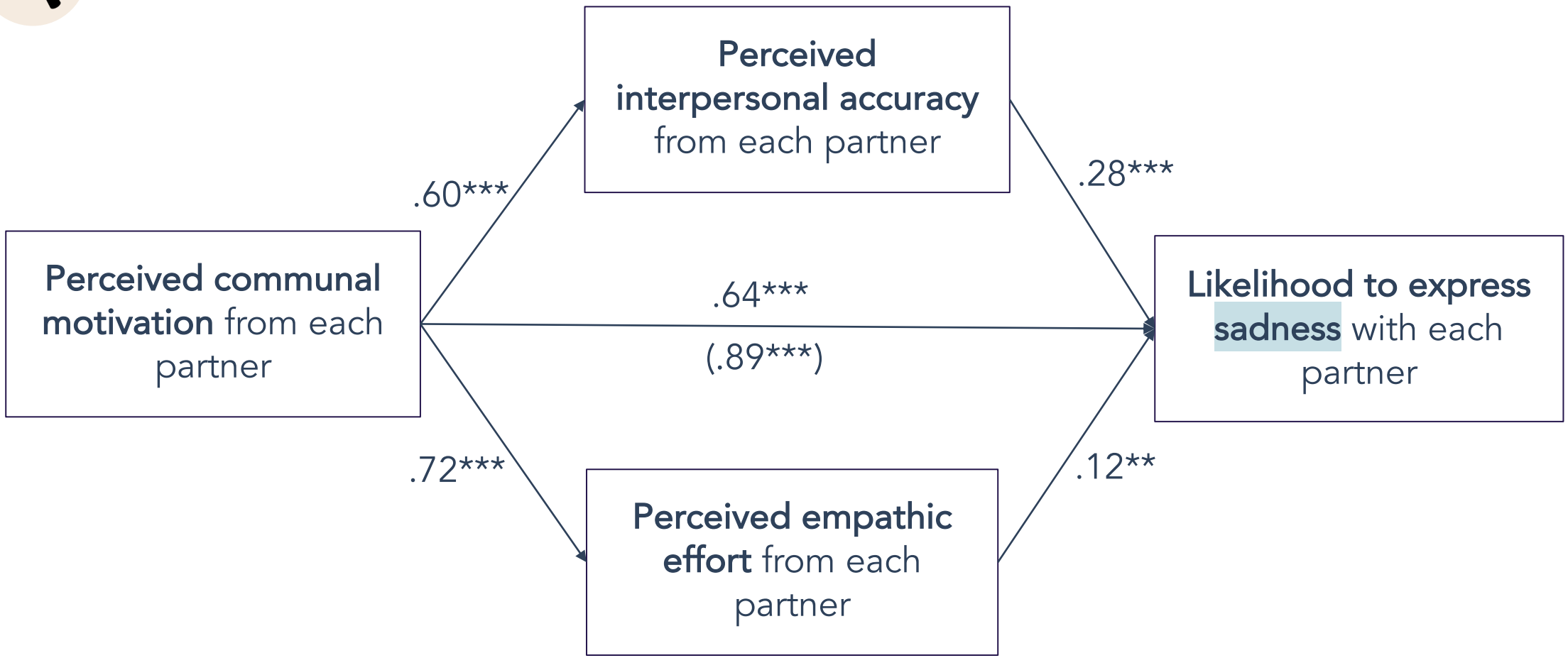
LIKELIHOOD TO EXPRESS

If I were to express sadness to _____,
_____ would see things exactly how I see them.
_____ would completely understand the situation from my point of view.
_____ would be really good at knowing how I was feeling.

PERCEIVED EFFORT

PERCEIVED ACCURACY

Results



All path coefficients are unstandardized betas
*p <.05, **p <.01, ***p < .001

Results

Indirect Effects		
Emotion	Interpersonal Accuracy	Empathic Effort
Happiness	.132***	.119**
Pride	.127***	.129**
Gratitude	.145***	.124**
Sadness	.167***	.089*
Anxiety	.168***	.127***
Anger	.117***	.088*
Guilt	.179***	.061

Perceived effort and perceived accuracy significantly mediated the association for all emotions, except guilt.

All path coefficients are unstandardized betas
*p <.05, **p <.01, ***p < .001

Results

Comparing Indirect Effects				
Emotion	Interpersonal Accuracy		Empathic Effort	$\Delta\chi^2$
Happiness	.132***	>	.119**	35.804
Pride	.127***		.129**	45.159
Gratitude	.145***	>	.124**	31.954
Sadness	.167***	>	.089*	60.848
Anxiety	.168***	>	.127***	48.731
Anger	.117***	>	.088*	55.366
Guilt	.179***	>	.061	124.229

Significantly poorer fit when the indirect effects of accuracy and effort were constrained to be equal, compared to a fully unconstrained model that allowed these effects to vary.

Perceiving accuracy from a partner is a stronger predictor of expression with a partner than perceiving effort.

All path coefficients are unstandardized betas
*p <.05, **p <.01, ***p < .001

Primary Takeaways

Perceiving accuracy is a stronger predictor of expression with a communal partner, compared to perceived effort.

However, people are still more likely to express emotions with communal partners that they perceive put in more effort.

Thank you!

Thoughts, feelings, questions, or comments?
Special thanks to the Rochester Relationships Lab.

All illustrations made by Storyset from www.storyset.com

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